

Chapter 176-1

The reason Chen Mian told Liang Shi about this matter was simple.

First, the person buying the painting was Qiu Zimin. Second, the person in the painting bore some resemblance to Liang Shi.

Liang Shi stared at the painting and studied it for a while but couldn't make heads or tails of it.

However, she did listen to Chen Mian tell a few interesting stories related to Shen Chi.

Rather than calling them interesting stories, it would be more accurate to call them romantic history.

Shen Chi was Chen Mian's teacher's teacher—the generation of her grandmaster, so to speak.

She was also a renowned painter from several decades ago.

She excelled at painting landscapes and people alike. Her style was distinctive, but what people talked about most was her family background and her romantic history.

Shen Chi's two childhood sweethearts were both her classmates. The three of them essentially grew up together.

One of them dated her but broke up with her not long after.

They were still able to maintain a friendship.

And though she had countless romantic rumors, her heart belonged to her white moonlight.

Later, her white moonlight got engaged, and she was diagnosed with late-stage cancer.

The trio just fell apart like that. After Shen Chi passed away, it was said that at her funeral hall, the two childhood sweethearts had a huge falling out.

However, these were all secrets among the wealthy elite, and not many people knew about them.

Chen Mian had also only heard her teacher mention it casually. Afterward, the topic became taboo.

She didn't know much.

Liang Shi listened to it as if it were a story that had nothing to do with her.

However, she asked Chen Mian to call her when she met with Qiu Zimin and Zhu Mingqi.

Chen Mian agreed.

Chapter 176-2

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Chen Mian met with Qiu Zimin first. At that time, Liang Shi was sitting in Chen Mian's studio, listening to the conversation between Qiu Zimin and Chen Mian through a door.

Chen Mian had no intention of selling Shen Chi's relic.

This painting was also something her teacher had passed down to her, and it held considerable sentimental value.

Moreover, people were now starting to bid for it.

Chen Mian didn't want things to escalate, so she politely declined Qiu Zimin.

But Qiu Zimin wouldn't relent: "Name your price. I want this painting."

Chen Mian said helplessly: "I'm sorry, I don't intend to sell it. If you're in this painting, there's also another person in it. To be honest with you, Ms. Zhu is also looking to buy this painting from me, but there's only one, and I personally want to keep it in my collection."

"But this is Shen Chi's painting," Qiu Zimin said.

Chen Mian nodded: "I know. It was left to me by my teacher."

Qiu Zimin paused: "You mean you're going to sell it to Zhu Mingqi?"

"No." Chen Mian replied: "I plan to keep it for my personal collection."

Qiu Zimin stared at her with considerable resentment.

But Chen Mian asked: "May I be so bold as to ask—why do you want this painting so badly?"

Qiu Zimin scoffed lightly: "If you know it's bold, why ask?"

"My teacher told me some things before." Chen Mian said: "I'm just verifying."

"What did your teacher tell you?" Qiu Zimin asked with a hint of nervousness.

Chen Mian paused briefly: "The person Teacher Shen cared about most is in this painting."

"Who?"

Chen Mian pointed to the person on the far right. Qiu Zimin's expression immediately changed. "Nonsense!"

Chen Mian shrugged: "That's what I heard. Besides, my teacher was with Teacher Shen until she passed away, so... it should have some credibility."

"Impossible." Qiu Zimin stood up. "You don't know anything. What nonsense are you spouting?"

Chen Mian made a gesture of invitation. "Believe it or not, that's up to you."

"You really won't sell?" Qiu Zimin gritted her teeth and made another offer: "Eighty million."

Chen Mian shook her head: "Not selling."

Qiu Zimin left with anger on her face, but before leaving, she turned back to look at Chen Mian. "Everything your teacher said is false."

Chen Mian: "....."

Chen Mian nodded indifferently: "Think whatever you want to think."

When Qiu Zimin left, she slammed the door with a thunderous bang.

Only then did Liang Shi come out, carefully examining the painting. She still didn't think it had eighty million yuan worth of potential.

Chen Mian smiled lightly: "Paintings need people to give them value, including artworks. It's not about how much the materials and concept are worth—what's more important is what's contained behind it."

Liang Shi barely understood.

Afterward, Chen Mian's meeting with Zhu Mingqi went the same way. Liang Shi was still hiding in the studio.

Chen Mian declined Zhu Mingqi with the same words.

After hearing it, Zhu Mingqi simply nodded and smiled gently: "No wonder your painting style is so similar to Shen Chi's. So you're her disciple."

"I was trained in Teacher Shen's lineage, but I never met her," Chen Mian said. "She would be my grandmaster."

Zhu Mingqi smiled: "But you're probably the one who learned the most like her. Very talented."

"So about this painting?" Chen Mian asked again.

"I don't need it anymore," Zhu Mingqi said. "For me, it's just a memory. It would be nice to buy it back, but it has a different meaning for you. It's fine for you to keep it in your private collection. Anyway, these memories are all in my mind—they're not something a painting can prove."

Zhu Mingqi was very kind to people. When the painting deal fell through, she said she wanted to look around Chen Mian's studio to see if there was anything else that caught her eye.

Such people were actually very friendly to contemporary painters because they would make them richer.

Rich people spending money on paintings gave painters better conditions to create.

No one would dislike that.

But because there was someone hiding in Chen Mian's studio, she was about to refuse. Unexpectedly, Liang Shi opened the door from inside and walked out.

This startled Zhu Mingqi. "Oh, there's someone else here..."

"Ms. Zhu." Liang Shi greeted her.

After seeing clearly that it was Liang Shi, Zhu Mingqi was surprised. "Ah? It's Miss Liang. You and Chen Mian... oh right, you two left together at the art museum last time. So is this also Miss Liang's home? How presumptuous of me."

"No." Liang Shi immediately denied it. "Chen Mian and I are just friends."

"Then you mentioned you were married last time?" Zhu Mingqi naturally started chatting with her.

Liang Shi nodded: "Yes, but not to Miss Chen."

Zhu Mingqi made an "oh" sound: "Sorry."

"It's fine." Liang Shi said: "I just had plans with Chen Mian, so I was waiting for her inside. If you want to look at paintings, please go ahead."

Saying this, she stepped back to Chen Mian's side. Chen Mian didn't understand her behavior.

But Liang Shi said quietly: "Make some money."

Chen Mian: "?"

Zhu Mingqi didn't think too much about it and didn't hold back either. She went into the studio and picked out a painting she liked, closing the deal at three hundred thousand.

It was originally something Chen Mian had painted for practice. The style was vastly different from her other works and didn't resemble Shen Chi's either.

But it was the most healing painting in her studio.

Zhu Mingqi remarked: "Miss Chen must have painted this full of hope. I can see love and hope in this painting."

Chen Mian was momentarily at a loss for words, not knowing how to respond.

This painting was indeed painted while thinking of Qi Jiao after she had too much to drink.

She had thought of their first meeting.

It was a very ordinary day, with sun, with wind, with crowded streets.

A young girl sat alone in her seat, tilting her head to look out the window. Originally a very gentle face, but it was full of sorrow. She suddenly turned her head, and their eyes met.

The corners of the young girl's lips lifted slightly, but there was no light in her eyes.

Later, she saw the light in her eyes.

It was painted while thinking of her smile, so the tones were very warm.

Zhu Mingqi had hit the mark completely. Chen Mian could only say awkwardly: "Mm."

Zhu Mingqi also looked at the other paintings in Chen Mian's studio and chatted with her about some of the works.

Finally, she discovered a painting turned away in the corner.

The artistic conception of this painting was also very beautiful.

In the vast snow, a girl was constantly gazing into the distance, where there was a miniaturized cluster of light and shadow that could vaguely be made out as a person.

This painting was the only one here with a name. It was called "Gazing."

It looked very bittersweet.

When Zhu Mingqi picked up this painting to admire it, Chen Mian subconsciously glanced at Liang Shi.

Zhu Mingqi said: "What is the person in this painting gazing at?"

"Gazing at her own longing," Chen Mian said.

Perhaps having found a kindred spirit, Chen Mian didn't hold back.

She went to the room next door and brought out two more paintings—one called "Chasing," one called "Letting Go."

It was clear that these three paintings were part of the same series.

At this moment, Liang Shi also understood.

The person in these paintings was Chen Mian, was Liang Wanwan, and was also the countless people who loved but couldn't have.

Chapter 176-3

Zhu Mingqi was very surprised. After understanding these three paintings, she offered 1.5 million to buy them. But Chen Mian shook her head, saying she would paint another one for Zhu Mingqi for free, but these three paintings were intended for someone else.

Zhu Mingqi didn't insist.

Because they had chatted so enjoyably, and it happened to be near lunchtime, Zhu Mingqi said she wanted to treat them to a meal.

Chen Mian glanced at Liang Shi. Neither of them refused.

When Liang Shi was about to leave, Chen Mian packed up the three paintings and handed them to Liang Shi, asking her to give them to Liang Wanwan at an appropriate time.

Liang Shi: "....."

As expected.

Later, when Liang Shi happened to go abroad for filming, she brought these three paintings to Liang Wanwan.

On the day she received these three paintings, Liang Wanwan cried uncontrollably in that foreign land.

Drunk, Liang Wanwan shouted at the rooftop: "Chen Mian, I give up."

"I will never like you again."

"You must be happy, Chen Mian."

Of course, that was all later.

At this moment, Liang Shi put the paintings in her car, then got into Zhu Mingqi's car together with Chen Mian.

In the car, Liang Shi was relatively quiet because Zhu Mingqi and Chen Mian were discussing art—a topic she couldn't contribute to.

However, Zhu Mingqi later changed the subject. "A-Shi, you're quite familiar with Xiao Xue, right?"

After saying this, she paused briefly: "You don't mind if I call you A-Shi, do you?"

"I don't mind." Liang Shi put away her phone and smiled awkwardly. "You still remember what happened that day."

If one really thought about it, accompanying Gu Yixue into that wedding hall and watching that absurd scene was one of the brave things Liang Shi had done in her lifetime.

Zhu Mingqi nodded: "Of course. I was quite startled at the time."

Liang Shi smiled lightly: "Sorry about that."

"It's fine, it wasn't your fault." Zhu Mingqi started chatting casually with her. "I really don't understand these kids nowadays. My eldest daughter's wedding was delayed for so long, and when they finally held it, that incident happened. Her father got so angry that night he fell ill."

Liang Shi: "...Ah, I see."

"It has nothing to do with you," Zhu Mingqi said. "But comparatively speaking, I do like Xiao Xue more. It seems my eldest also prefers Xiao Xue. That girl Gu Chunmian—her heart isn't in the right place."

Liang Shi listened silently, not daring to voice any opinions.

She wasn't really familiar with Gu Chunmian to begin with, and she knew very little about the relationship between Gu Yixue and Shen Fenghe. When she bravely crashed the wedding venue with Gu Yixue, she was just doing it from a friend's standpoint.

Besides, it couldn't really be called snatching the bride.

At most, it could be called picking up what others discarded.¹

"I've said too much again." Zhu Mingqi belatedly realized she had shared all her thoughts and smiled helplessly. "I'm an old woman. I don't socialize much normally, so whenever I chat with young people, I tend to talk a lot."

"It's fine." Liang Shi smiled lightly. "Please go ahead. I'm listening."

Zhu Mingqi looked at her again and once more expressed regret: "If only you weren't married, Little Liang."

Liang Shi: "?"

"I've always wanted to introduce you to my second daughter." Zhu Mingqi said.

Liang Shi: "?"

Liang Shi cleared her throat, accidentally choking on her own saliva, and started coughing frantically.

This startled Zhu Mingqi.

"Are you okay?" Zhu Mingqi immediately apologized. "Sorry, I didn't mean to. I'm not saying you should get divorced or anything. I was just expressing how much I like you. Please don't misunderstand."

Liang Shi: "....."

It took quite a while before Liang Shi calmed down, though her face was flushed red from coughing.

Zhu Mingqi said helplessly: "I just like you too much. I felt a connection with you from the moment I saw you. How can a young girl be so beautiful?"

Liang Shi: "....."

She looked at Zhu Mingqi.

The appreciation in Zhu Mingqi's eyes couldn't be faked. She really did like her a lot.

Liang Shi smiled politely: "Thank you for your kind regard."

"Just don't feel offended." Zhu Mingqi said. "Since you're married, I certainly wish you and your spouse a hundred years of harmony."

Liang Shi nodded: "Thank you."

She didn't know what else to say.

"As for my second daughter." Zhu Mingqi shook her head. "Her temper is too stubborn, just like her father. A complete love-brain,² nothing like me at all. If she can't be with you, that's her lack of fortune."

Liang Shi: "...?"

Shen Hui was a love-brain?

Well, there was a little bit of that.

But...

"You don't know yet?" Liang Shi asked tentatively.

"Know what?" Zhu Mingqi asked.

Liang Shi immediately waved her hand: "No... nothing."

It seemed she still didn't know about Shen Hui and Zhao Xuning.

"What is it exactly?" Her attitude aroused Zhu Mingqi's curiosity. "Being all hesitant like that—is it about A-Hui?"

Liang Shi still didn't say: "You'll know when the time comes."

Silently praying for Zhao Xuning online.

Zhu Mingqi laughed: "So mysterious."

Amid the conversation and laughter, they arrived at the restaurant.

The place Zhu Mingqi brought them to was a high-end restaurant. One needed to spend at least a million at this establishment to even have a name there, but the service and dishes were genuinely excellent.

It was clear that Zhu Mingqi truly liked them and wasn't stingy at all.

1. "撿漏" (jiǎn lòu) literally means "picking up a leak" or finding a bargain that others missed. In this context, Liang Shi is humorously saying that rather than "stealing" the bride, they were just picking up someone who had been abandoned/discarded at the altar. ⇐
2. "戀愛腦" (liàn'ài nǎo) literally "love brain" - a popular Chinese internet slang term describing someone who becomes completely consumed by romantic love, often to the point of losing rationality and making love their top priority above all else. ⇐

Chapter 176-4

This meal was also very enjoyable.

Although Zhu Mingqi often jokingly called herself an old woman, she was very insightful and had her own thoughts when discussing art with Chen Mian. When chatting about TV dramas and films with Liang Shi, she could also talk eloquently.

Liang Shi was surprised at how much she knew. But Zhu Mingqi waved her hand dismissively: "An old woman like me has nothing to do all day. Besides looking at paintings, I just watch TV dramas and films. I'm too lazy to go out, so these are my only hobbies."

Both Liang Shi and Chen Mian really liked her.

When they finished eating, Liang Shi's phone rang.

It was from Zhao Xuning, asking where she was.

"At Tianxiang Residence," Liang Shi said.

"Eating somewhere so luxurious?" Zhao Xuning was surprised. "With Xu Qingzhu?"

"No." Liang Shi cleared her throat. "With someone you'd never expect."

Zhao Xuning was still recovering, so she didn't ask more. She just asked Liang Shi to come to the hospital later.

"Okay." Liang Shi agreed.

After hanging up and walking back to the private room, she happened to pass by Zhu Mingqi. She was clearly just walking by, but after passing her, she stopped and turned around to stare at her hair.

Zhu Mingqi looked up and asked: "What's wrong?"

Liang Shi answered instinctively: "I saw a white hair."

Zhu Mingqi was taken aback: "Huh?"

Liang Shi: "I might have been mistaken though."

"Take another look." Zhu Mingqi parted her own hair. Liang Shi had no choice but to stand up and walk over. As she bent down, she saw that white hair—it stood out conspicuously among the dense black strands.

Liang Shi asked if she wanted it plucked out.

Zhu Mingqi immediately said: "Pull it out."

Liang Shi gently pressed one hand on her head while the other pinched that strand of hair and swiftly pulled it out.

Although she had tried her best to minimize the pain, Zhu Mingqi still gasped.

But it only hurt for a moment.

Liang Shi showed her the white hair, then returned to her seat and threw the hair into the trash can.

In fact, that strand of hair was still in the palm of her hand. She had only made a fake motion.

Zhu Mingqi was over there reminiscing: "Ever since my youngest daughter passed away, these white hairs have been sprouting up constantly. Sometimes I lament that I really am getting old."

Liang Shi and Chen Mian couldn't contribute to this conversation.

And this was the first time Liang Shi had done something like this. She still hadn't recovered from the fake motion she had just made.

Zhu Mingqi reminisced alone: "When I was young, I was quite pretty too. Many people chased after me. I'm really not joking with you—when I was young, I was probably similar to Little Liang. Walking down the street back then, many talent scouts would hand me their business cards."

As she spoke, she looked at Liang Shi. "I have to say, looking at it this way, Little Liang does resemble how I looked when I was young."

Liang Shi smiled awkwardly: "You flatter me."

After this meal was finished, Zhu Mingqi paid the bill. She also told Chen Mian that if she painted anything in the future, she should show it to her first.

She would definitely fight to be the first buyer.

Chen Mian smiled lightly: "I'll give them to you for free in the future."

"How can that be?" Zhu Mingqi said. "Art has value."

Chapter 176-5

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After leaving Tianxiang Residence, Chen Mian went home while Liang Shi took a detour to the hospital.

As soon as she got in the car, she put Zhu Mingqi's white hair into a sealed bag.

Just one white hair in a transparent sealed bag looked somewhat out of place.

So she simply pulled out one of her own and put it in together.

The black and white hairs intertwined together. For some reason, Liang Shi's heart was pounding like a drum.

When she arrived at the hospital, Zhao Xuning was lying in bed reading a book. She looked like she had mostly recovered.

"Have you eaten?" Liang Shi asked as soon as she entered.

"Not yet." Zhao Xuning said. "I'm not hungry yet."

"Did you eat this morning?" Liang Shi asked.

Zhao Xuning: "Sort of."

"What do you mean 'sort of'?" Liang Shi placed the food she had foresightedly packed on her bedside table. "How can eating be 'sort of'?"

"Shen Hui brought me a piece of bread." Zhao Xuning said.

"Where's Shen Hui?" Liang Shi asked. "I saw her room was empty when I came."

"She was discharged this morning." Zhao Xuning marked the page she was reading with a bookmark and set it aside. "She still has matters to deal with regarding Wu Li."

"....."

"So does this count as you two getting back together?" Liang Shi asked the question she most wanted to ask.

Zhao Xuning paused. "I guess... so."

It's just that they hadn't returned to how they were before.

"But I'm curious—what did you discover that made you go stop it?" Liang Shi asked.

Zhao Xuning lowered her head to open the packaging, her tone casual. "Wu Li's ex-girlfriend is seven months pregnant."

Liang Shi: "?"

Because abortion wasn't allowed here, if you got pregnant, you could only give birth.

But Wu Li's ex-girlfriend?

"What does her ex-girlfriend have to do with her?" Liang Shi was confused. "She's not her current girlfriend."

"Wu Li dumped her after getting together with Shen Hui. She's still paying child support every month." Zhao Xuning's voice was very soft. "When that girl came to our hospital for a checkup, the doctor recommended hospitalization because of abnormal fetal positioning. But she didn't have the money. When she called Wu Li... Wu Li was on the way to Huichang Temple with Shen Hui."

Liang Shi: "....."

This was absolute scum behavior.

"So you went to find Shen Hui?" Liang Shi asked.

Zhao Xuning nodded. "I can't control what happens to others, but Shen Hui cannot marry Wu Li."

"Then why didn't you tell Shen Hui?" Liang Shi sat by her hospital bed and said with some regret. "Shen Hui had Shen Siyan investigate, but Shen Siyan didn't say anything either."

Everyone was protecting Shen Hui in their own way.

At the mention of Shen Hui, Zhao Xuning finally smiled. "She especially likes to take responsibility onto herself. I didn't want her to think this situation happened because of her. She would definitely feel guilty toward Wu Li's ex-girlfriend."

Liang Shi: "....."

Perhaps this was the understanding that came from years of being in love?

Looking at it this way, Liang Shi was still moved by Zhao Xuning.

"Honestly, if I were Shen Hui and I found out everything, I would definitely be very moved." Liang Shi said.

Zhao Xuning: "?"

Zhao Xuning glanced at her indifferently, as if to say—don't make me sick.

Liang Shi: "....."

"Go away." Liang Shi said. "Anyway, congratulations to Dr. Zhao on reconciling. Don't repeat the same mistakes, okay?"

"Wish me well, please."

As Zhao Xuning spoke, she turned and pulled out a transparent sealed bag from under her pillow, handing it to Liang Shi. "Take this to a testing facility for identification."

"What is this?" Liang Shi was confused.

"Shen Hui's hair." Zhao Xuning said.

Liang Shi: "?"

"I won't be the one doing this test." Zhao Xuning said. "If Shen Hui finds out, she'll make a fuss at me."

Liang Shi: "....."

Liang Shi took out the sealed bag she had prepared. "I got Zhu Mingqi's hair."

Zhao Xuning: "?"

After a moment of silence, Zhao Xuning took out her phone and contacted a friend, then had Liang Shi take the samples over.

The testing department was on the seventh floor of the hospital. Liang Shi went up without any obstacles and was told the results would be ready in two hours.

Liang Shi agreed, but when she went downstairs and got out of the elevator, her legs inexplicably went weak for a moment.

When she returned to Zhao Xuning's room afterward, she felt restless the whole time.

There was just this inexplicable sense of nervousness.

Zhao Xuning told her to go do her own things, but Liang Shi said she was off today and had nothing to do.

But she really was nervous. When she was nervous, she wanted to talk to someone to distract herself. Unfortunately, Zhao Xuning was focused on her book and didn't have much to chat about with her.

Chapter 176-6

Liang Shi could only message Xu Qingzhu: [I just sent my hair and Zhu Mingqi and the others' hair for testing.]

Xu Qingzhu quickly caught the key point: [The others?]

Liang Shi: [And Shen Hui's too.]

Xu Qingzhu: [Dr. Zhao got it?]

Liang Shi: [Mm.]

Xu Qingzhu: [Are you nervous?]

Liang Shi: [...Mm, my heart is pounding.]

Xu Qingzhu sent a voice message: "Where are you now?"

Liang Shi: [Zhao Xuning's hospital room.]

Xu Qingzhu: "I'll be there soon. Wait for me."

Zhao Xuning, sitting to the side reading a book: "?"

"Why haven't you left yet?" Zhao Xuning frowned slightly.

Liang Shi: "?"

"I can't even sit here for a bit?" Liang Shi said. "How are you still so arrogant when you're sick?"

Zhao Xuning: "I don't want to eat dog food,¹ so leave."

Liang Shi: "....."

"Let Xu Qingzhu comfort you." Zhao Xuning poked her arm with the book. "Don't come to me looking for attention."

Liang Shi: "?"

Liang Shi wasn't in the mood to argue with her. She went out to find Xu Qingzhu.

Just as she got out of the elevator downstairs, she happened to run into Xu Qingzhu. With her big belly, Xu Qingzhu asked her: "Have you had lunch?"

"Yes." Liang Shi supported her. "I ate with Chen Mian and that person."

The two talked as they walked outside.

It had to be said, after seeing Xu Qingzhu, Liang Shi felt much better overall.

Inexplicably reassured.

Xu Qingzhu took her outside, where people came and went on the streets.

It was a bit hot at this time of day. Xu Qingzhu had her drive, and the two went to a nearby hotel and got a room.

Liang Shi was stunned: "What are you doing?"

"Taking a nap." Xu Qingzhu took back the room card and glanced at her. "What were you thinking?"

Liang Shi: "....."

Liang Shi went upstairs with her. As soon as they entered, Xu Qingzhu changed her shoes and lay down on the bed, drowsiness overtaking her.

But Liang Shi still maintained a bit of nervousness.

Xu Qingzhu patted the spot next to her. "Baby, come lie down."

Liang Shi lay down, hugged her, buried her head in her neck, and said in an aggrieved voice: "Wife, I'm nervous."

"It's okay." Xu Qingzhu said. "We'll know the results soon."

"What do we do once we know?" Liang Shi said. "I haven't figured it out yet..."

"And yet you went ahead and did it?" Xu Qingzhu laughed lightly. "Our Teacher Liang was so brave today."

Liang Shi mumbled: "Zhao Xuning forced me into it."²

Xu Qingzhu just reassured her: "It's fine. We'll discuss it after we know the results."

Xu Qingzhu patted her back. "I'm here~ With you, and our babies too."

It was just a simple sentence, yet it smoothed out Liang Shi's anxious emotions.

Xu Qingzhu had recently developed the habit of taking afternoon naps. She always had to sleep for a while after eating. Liang Shi caught her yawn and yawned along with her.

The room temperature was just right. Smelling the familiar scent on Xu Qingzhu, drowsiness quickly washed over her.

When Liang Shi woke up, Xu Qingzhu was already standing by the window looking at the scenery.

The room they booked was on the thirtieth-something floor with huge floor-to-ceiling windows. The scenery of the entire city was visible at a glance.

Liang Shi asked hoarsely: "How long did I sleep?"

"Half an hour." Xu Qingzhu said. "Get up now."

Liang Shi felt a bit disappointed: "Only half an hour."

"You can't sleep too long during afternoon naps." Xu Qingzhu walked over and reached out to pull her up from the bed, backlit by the light.

Pregnant Xu Qingzhu was wearing loose clothes, with a casual low ponytail, completely bare-faced, but her skin was flawless. Liang Shi reached out to her, and the moment their hands overlapped, Liang Shi sat up and hugged her waist, resting her head against her belly.

Her ear pressed against her belly, quietly listening to the activity inside.

"Did they kick you?" Liang Shi asked.

"They did." Xu Qingzhu said. "How else do you think I woke up?"

"My baby has it so hard." Liang Shi looked up, raising her hand to pat Xu Qingzhu's head, but due to the height difference, she couldn't reach it. She could only gently pinch her chin. But Xu Qingzhu stroked her head. "It's okay. Those two aren't too fussy."

"Baby." Liang Shi was still nervous, nuzzling her head against her belly. "I'm still scared."

"What are you scared of?" Xu Qingzhu said. "Think about it—once this test is done, you'll have peace of mind. Whether it is or isn't, we'll have an answer."

"Besides, the Shen family is pretty good." Xu Qingzhu flicked her forehead. "Hurry up and get up. I want to get some milk tea."

"Iced or hot?" Liang Shi stood up and hugged her from behind.

"Hot." Xu Qingzhu said.

"That can be satisfied."

Afraid of being recognized when going out, Liang Shi put on a mask and put one on Xu Qingzhu as well. Then she took Xu Qingzhu's hand, went downstairs, and headed out.

Right across the street was a milk tea shop with a long queue.

Xu Qingzhu and Liang Shi walked over and waited, chatting casually.

"Don't you need to work this afternoon?" Liang Shi asked.

Xu Qingzhu shook her head: "I finished everything this morning."

"....."

Soon it was their turn. Liang Shi ordered two cups of pearl milk tea. While standing there waiting, she felt probing gazes coming her way, but when Liang Shi turned around to look, she couldn't find where the probing gazes were coming from.

In the end, she could only let it go.

But soon, she was on the hot search.

Her agent called to tell her about it. "You were photographed with President Xu."

Liang Shi: "....."

The trending topic was #Liang Shi Married#.

Chang Hui asked what to do—should they take this opportunity to go public?

Liang Shi logged onto Weibo herself. After scanning through the comments, she found that it was exactly what happened just now at the milk tea shop entrance. She and Xu Qingzhu were holding hands in line buying milk tea, and someone had taken photos of their side profiles and backs.

The netizens' comments were pretty positive. After all, she was an actress, not a traffic idol.³

So she took the opportunity to make an official announcement.

@Liang Shi: Yep, married.

She directly pinned this Weibo post, and commented: She's not in the industry. Please don't dig into it.

Chang Hui had long established a personal studio for her. When the studio reposted her Weibo, the caption was: Teacher Liang and her wife are so loving~ But please focus more on the artist's work and stay away from the artist's private life.

They didn't hide anything.

Some things—the more you try to hide them, the more it triggers the public's rebellious psychology.

It was better to be open and generous about it from the start, filtering out those fans who weren't your target audience early on. It would save a lot of trouble later.

Of course, doing this would definitely come with a price to pay.

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1. "吃狗糧" (eating dog food) is Chinese internet slang for being subjected to public displays of affection by couples. Single people or those not involved "eat dog food" when they witness couples being lovey-dovey in front of them. ↩
 2. "趕鴨子上架" (forcing ducks onto a perch) is a Chinese idiom meaning to force someone to do something they're not prepared for or don't want to do—essentially being pushed into an uncomfortable situation. ↩
 3. "流量" (traffic/traffic star) refers to celebrities whose fame is primarily based on their ability to generate online traffic and fan engagement rather than actual talent or artistic merit. These celebrities often rely heavily on their fan base for popularity. ↩